Rushing to his next appointment, lunch with the crown prince of Libya, Hasan Al Rida Al Sansusi, Kennedy told his advisers to be back at 6:00 p.m. to continue the discussion. “I just hate to even waste these six hours,” one can hear the president saying on the secretly made tape of the conversations just before the meeting broke up.[16]

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KENNEDY HAD LEFT THE LATE-MORNING MEETING ON CUBA convinced that he had to use military force. That conviction stayed with him for the rest of the day. At lunch with Al Rida Al Sansusi, Kennedy told Adlai Stevenson, his representative at the United Nations, “I suppose the alternatives are to go in by air and wipe them out or to take other steps to render the weapons inoperable.” Stevenson urged the president to “explore the possibilities of the peaceful solution” before deciding on an air strike, but Kennedy was not responsive. Robert Kennedy, who could read his brother’s mind better than anyone else, believed that he was leaning toward a military solution to the crisis and said as much to the CIA group that was running clandestine operations against Cuba; he met with them in the afternoon.[17]

Throughout the day, Kennedy kept struggling to understand why Khrushchev had decided to do what he did, but could not find an answer. “We certainly have been wrong about what he’s trying to do in Cuba,” he told his advisers when they began their evening meeting on the rapidly evolving crisis. General Maxwell D. Taylor, the sixty-year-old chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, whom Kennedy had first asked to lead a group investigating the Bay of Pigs disaster and then appointed to the position held earlier by General Lyman Lemnitzer, stressed the psychological impact the Soviet missiles in Cuba would have on the Americans. His chiefs of staff argued that the Soviet missiles in Cuba would significantly change the strategic balance. But McNamara was skeptical. He personally believed that they would not change it at all. “I agree, what difference does it make?” said Kennedy in reaction to McNamara’s suggestion. “They have got enough to blow us up anyway.”[18]